

Rainforests



THE BIRDS OF THE lush rainforests of northeastern Australia resemble those of New Guinea more than the rest of Australia. The two regions were joined for much of their history and have a similar warm, wet climate with rain all year. Their rainforests are rich in fruit trees for

birds to feed on, but are rapidly being cleared to make way for houses, farms, dams, and mines.

New Guinea's high mountains; deep, isolated valleys; and lack of mammal predators have allowed a huge variety of birds to evolve there, including the spectacular bowerbirds and birds-of-paradise. There are also more kinds of kingfisher in New Guinea than anywhere else in the world.

BOWERBIRDS

Most male bowerbirds do not have colorful and elaborate feathers. Instead, they build "bowers"—a display shelter made out of twigs—and some decorate them with colorful objects. Females choose to mate with the males that have the best bowers, then go off to build their nests safely hidden in the forest.

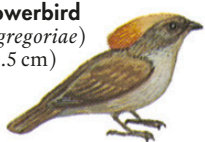


"Avenue" bower decorated with blue things.



Satin bowerbird
(*Ptilonorhynchus violaceus*)
Length: 1 ft 1 in (33 cm)

MacGregor's bowerbird
(*Amblyornis macgregoriae*)
Length: 10 in (25.5 cm)



"Maypole" bower; bird has large, orange crest.



Vogelkop bowerbird
(*Amblyornis inornata*)
Length: 1 ft (30 cm)



Complex "hut" bower; bird has no crest and feathers are a dull color.



Victoria crowned pigeon
(*Goura victoria*)
Length: 2 ft 5 in (74 cm)

Victoria crowned pigeon

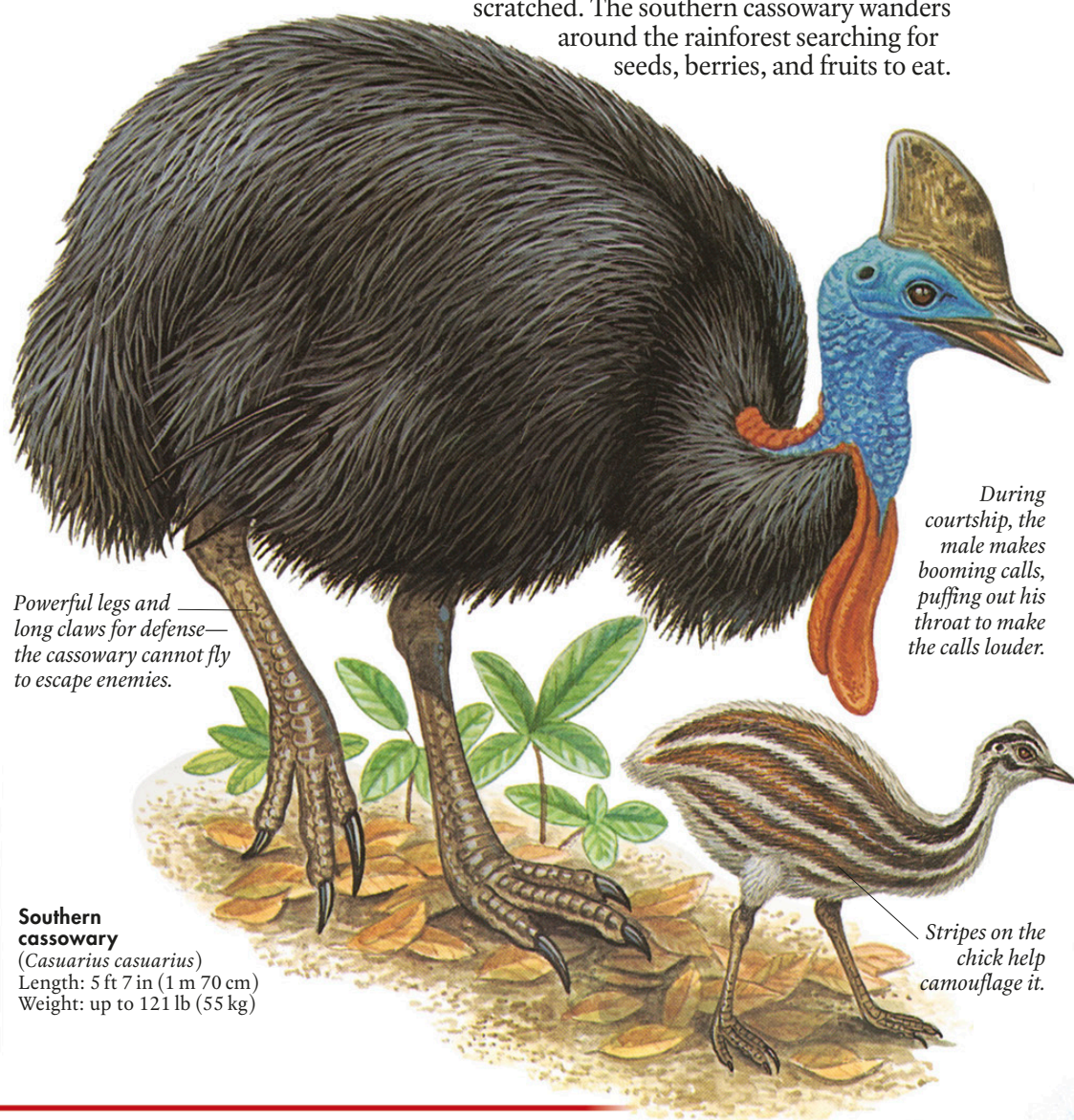
This is one of the biggest pigeons in the world—the size of a large chicken.

Despite its size, this pigeon nests up to 49 ft (15 m) high in the trees. The male Victoria crowned pigeon bows his head during his courtship display to show off his splendid crest to the female. At the same time, he spreads his tail out, fans it up and down, and makes a booming call.

These pigeons fly up into trees and perch on branches to escape danger.

Southern cassowary

This huge cassowary is the same height and weight as a small human being. It uses the tall, horny casque on its head to push aside the tangled forest undergrowth. Its long, hairlike feathers protect its body and stop it getting scratched. The southern cassowary wanders around the rainforest searching for seeds, berries, and fruits to eat.



Powerful legs and long claws for defense—the cassowary cannot fly to escape enemies.

During courtship, the male makes booming calls, puffing out his throat to make the calls louder.

Southern cassowary
(*Casuarius casuarius*)
Length: 5 ft 7 in (1 m 70 cm)
Weight: up to 121 lb (55 kg)

Stripes on the chick help camouflage it.